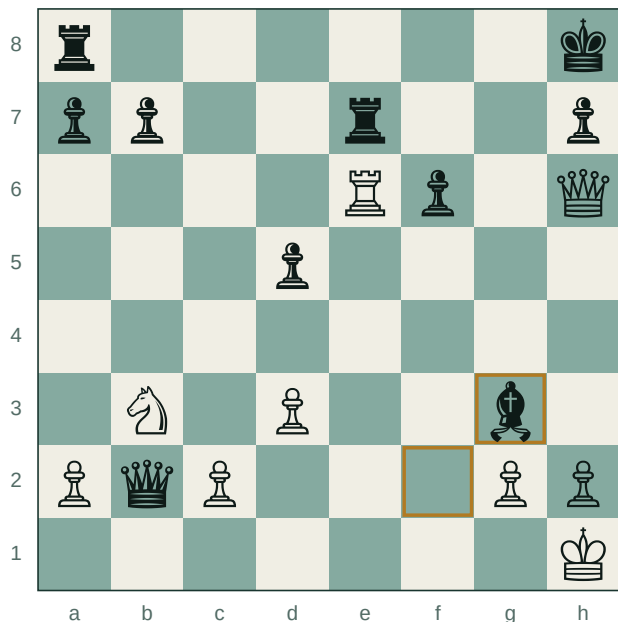


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 25

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 24...Bxg3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

25. Rxe7 Qb1+ 26. Nc1 Qxc1+ 27. Qxc1

25.Rxe7 The rook captures the rook on e7. Recorded reply: **25...Qb1+**.

26.Nc1 The knight moves from b3 to c1. Recorded reply: **26...Qxc1+**.

27.Qxc1 The queen captures the queen on c1.

At the end, nominal material is White 19 / Black 13 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +11. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +11:** the balance goes from -5 to +6. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on h8. Absolute pin: pawn on h7.